

Motion Verbs Without Fact of Motion

Laurestine Bradford

NAMED 2026

May 21, 2026

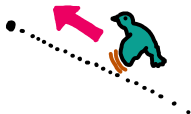
Université du Québec à Trois-Rivières

Table of Contents

1. Intro to Motion Descriptions in Tlingit
2. Progressive Consistently Describes a Transition
3. “Motion” Verbs are Merely Spatial
4. Wrinkle: Perfective Motion
5. Summary

1. Intro to Motion Descriptions in Tlingit
2. Progressive Consistently Describes a Transition
3. “Motion” Verbs are Merely Spatial
4. Wrinkle: Perfective Motion
5. Summary

Elements of a Motion Description

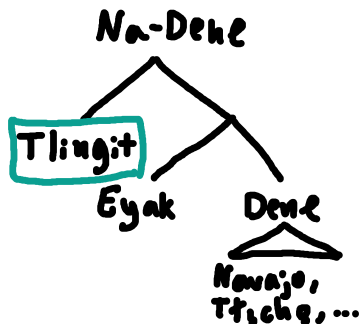


From (Talmy, 1975) cited in (Talmy, 2000):

- **Figure**, thing that's moving
- Path, where in space it moves (with respect to Ground)
- **Manner**, how it moves
- **Fact of Motion**, the fact that it's moving at all

Claim by Talmy (2000): "The 'fact-of-Motion' component of a Motion event always appears in the verb root."

Tlingit (*Lingít* [łín'kít])



- About 100 fluent speakers as of 2018. (Twitchell, 2018)
- Numerous revitalization programs, including language nest, school and university classes, adult classes. (Burge, 2024)

Tlingit Verb Structure

(1) gaxtoodats'éit'
PROSP.1PL.S.APSV.skin

“We’re going to skin.”

(Eggleston, 2017)

- Monosyllabic root.
- Derivational morphology can add idiomatic meaning and change argument structure.
- Subject and object pronouns and agreement interleaved with derivational morphology.
- Aspectual morphology interleaved with derivational morphology.
- Morpheme order may not reflect semantic scope (Crippen, 2019).

Tlingit Perfective and Imperfective

- (2) Loon awliyéx. Laax tsu awliyéx.
bark 3>3.PFV.make red.cedar also 3>3.PFV.make
“He carved bark. He carved red cedar.”
(Dauenhauer & Dauenhauer, 1987)
- (3) Woosh gunayáade át; daa sá yan wulihásh áwé
RECIP different thing; what Q ground PFV.drift FOC
alyéix.
3>3.IPFV.make
“Different kinds of material; whatever had drifted ashore is
what he carved.” (Dauenhauer & Dauenhauer, 1987)

yaa nat'éin
“It’s getting hot.”

- **Proclitic** *yaa*, *kei*, or *yei* depending on conjugation class.
 - For spatial verbs, *yaa* is “along”, *kei* is “up”, and *yei* is “down”.
- **N-conjugation prefix** (no matter what conjugation class).
- For CV roots, **-n suffix** and root vowel change.

Progressive can be either perfective or imperfective, but is usually imperfective.

Anatomy of a Tlingit Motion Description

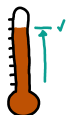
(4) Aadé yaa ndakín.
it.toward along NCNJ.MID.fly.SG
“He/she/it is flying there.” (Eggleston, 2017)

- “Motion” root which often restricts figure and/or manner
- Progressive aspect
- Optional PP with explicit path

1. Intro to Motion Descriptions in Tlingit
2. Progressive Consistently Describes a Transition
3. “Motion” Verbs are Merely Spatial
4. Wrinkle: Perfective Motion
5. Summary

Tlingit Aspectual Classes

Degree Achievement



- (5) Uwat'áa.
PFV.hot
“It's [gotten] hot.”

State



- (7) Litseen.
STV.strong
“S/he is strong.”

Motion



- (6) Du jeet aawa.áx.
3SG.H hand.to 3>3.PFV.hide.be.placed
“S/he gave it to him/her [hide/fabric].”

Activity



- (8) Axá.
3>3.eat
“S/he is eating it.”

(Eggleston, 2017)

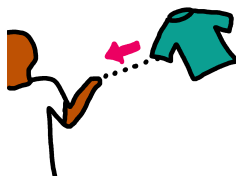
Progressive Degree Achievements



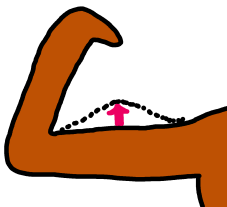
- (9) Yaa nat'éin.
along NCNJ.hot
“It’s getting hot.”

(Eggleston, 2017)

Progressive Motion Descriptions



- (10) Du jeedé yaa ana.áx.
3SG.H hand.toward along 3>3.NC.NJ.hide.be.placed
“S/he’s giving it to him/her [hide/fabric].”
(Eggleston, 2017)



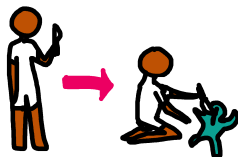
(11) Kei naltseen.

up NCNJ.strong

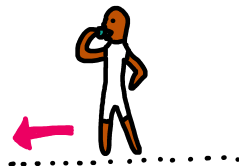
“S/he is becoming strong.”

(Eggleston, 2017)

Progressive Activities



- (12) **Yaa** anatséit'.
along 3>3.NCNJ.skin
“S/he is starting to skin it.”



- (13) **Yaa** ana_xéin.
along 3>3.NCNJ.eat
“S/he is going along eating it.”
(Eggleston, 2017)

Summary of Effect of Progressive

Degree Achievement



Increasing degree

Motion Description



Advancing on path

State



Transition into state

Activity



Transition *or* motion

1. Intro to Motion Descriptions in Tlingit
2. Progressive Consistently Describes a Transition
3. “Motion” Verbs are Merely Spatial
4. Wrinkle: Perfective Motion
5. Summary

Imperfective “motion” verbs describe position

Progressive



- (14) Du jeedé yaa ana.áx.
3SG.H hand.toward along 3>3.NCNJ.hide.be.placed
“S/he’s giving it to him/her [hide/fabric].”

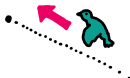
Plain Imperfective



- (15) Át .áx.
it.at hide.be.placed
“It’s sitting there [hide/fabric].”

Imperfective “motion” verbs are position (when they exist)

Progressive



- (16) Aadé yaa ndakín.
it.toward along NCNJ.MID.fly.SG
“He/she/it is flying there.”

Plain Imperfective

(does not exist)

(Eggleston, 2017)

Imperfective stative “motion” verbs

Progressive



- (17) Aadé yaa anal.át.
it.toward along 3>3.NCNJ.be.placed.PL

“S/he is carrying them there.”

(Eggleston, 2017)

Stative Imperfective



- (18) Áx nali.átk.
it.at NCNJ.STV.be.placed.PL.REP

“They (distributed) lie here and there along it.”

(Crippen, 2019)

Anatomy of a Tlingit Motion Description Revisited

(19) Aadé yaa ndakín.
it.toward along NCNJ.MID.fly.SG

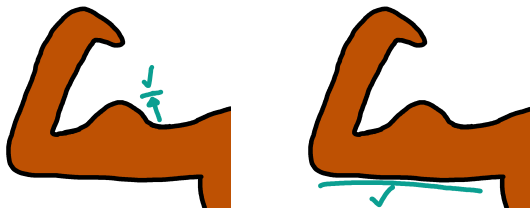
"He/she/it is flying there."

(Eggleston, 2017)

- “Motion” root expresses that a figure is located in space and perhaps describes an action/manner (like flying).
- Optional PP with explicit path provides a scale on which transition is possible.
- Progressive aspect presupposes that a scale exists and expresses ongoing transition along that scale.

1. Intro to Motion Descriptions in Tlingit
2. Progressive Consistently Describes a Transition
3. “Motion” Verbs are Merely Spatial
4. Wrinkle: Perfective Motion
5. Summary

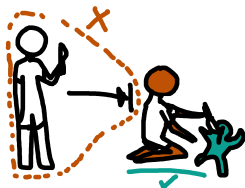
Perfective aspect is usually ambiguous between transition and result



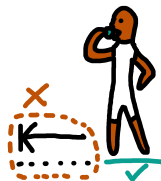
- (20) Wulitseen.
PFV.strong

“S/he became strong.” / “S/he was strong.”

Perfective aspect of activities must describe complete activity



- (21) Aawats'éit'.
3>3.PFV.skin
“S/he skinned it.”



- (22) Aawa_xáa.
3>3.PFV.eat
“S/he ate it.”
(Eggleston, 2017)

Perfective aspect of motion verbs can describe transition



- (23) Du jeet aawa.áx.
3SG.H hand.to 3>3.PFV.hide.be.placed
“S/he gave it to him/her [hide/fabric].” (Eggleston, 2017)

Anatomy of a Tlingit Motion Description, Perfective

(24) Aadé wdikeen.
it.toward PFV.MID.fly.SG
“He/she/it flew toward there.” (Eggleston, 2017)

- “Motion” root expresses that a figure is located in space and perhaps describes an action/manner (like flying).
- Optional PP with explicit path provides a scale on which transition is possible.
- Perfective aspect, *when the verb phrase contains a scale*, can express transition along that scale.

1. Intro to Motion Descriptions in Tlingit
2. Progressive Consistently Describes a Transition
3. “Motion” Verbs are Merely Spatial
4. Wrinkle: Perfective Motion
5. Summary

- Describing ongoing motion in Tlingit requires progressive aspect.
- Progressive aspect can add motion semantics to verbs that otherwise never have it.
- A “motion” verb without progressive aspect still encodes a spatial relationship and restricts the figure, but does not entail motion.
- I am not sure how to incorporate perfective motion.

Acknowledgments

Aatlein gunalchéesh to *Anyàłashâsh* Sam Johnston, *Shuwuteen* Margaret Bob, and *Kudagaan* Madeleine Jackson for their language expertise.

To James Crippen, Seth Cable, Luis Alonso-Ovalle, the McGill Syn-Sem Reading Group, the Na-Dene Reading/Working Group, and reviewers at SULA and NAMED for insightful comments.

To Fiona Smith for help with corpus data.

To Millie Hall, Tim Hall, Andy Hall, Corinne Johnston, and Connie Jules for huge assistance during fieldwork trips.

To the Fonds de Recherche du Québec, the American Philosophical Society, and the Jacobs Research Fund for financial support.



Fonds de recherche – Nature et technologies
Fonds de recherche – Santé
Fonds de recherche – Société et culture

- Describing ongoing motion in Tlingit requires progressive aspect.
- Progressive aspect can add motion semantics to verbs that otherwise never have it.
- A “motion” verb without progressive aspect still encodes a spatial relationship and restricts the figure, but does not entail motion.
- I am not sure how to incorporate perfective motion.

Bonus: Prospective motion can describe result

Context: *Two people Dave and Bill are talking. Dave is going out of town, so he says this.*

- (25) Tléix' sánde x'áakx Jóono dé
one sunday span.at Juneau toward
kkwagóot.

1SG.S.PROSP.go.SG

"I'm gonna go to Juneau for one week."

Speaker comment: You see like, a week, from Sunday to Sunday, you see? Between there. You'll be gone one week.

References I

- Burge, H. D. (2024). *Woosh jín toolshát yeisú, we're still holding each other's hands: relationships and revitalization in Lingít country* (Doctoral dissertation, University of British Columbia). doi: 10.14288/1.0439964
- Crippen, J. A. (2019). *The syntax in Tlingit verbs* (Doctoral dissertation, University of British Columbia). doi: 10.14288/1.0388221
- Dauenhauer, N. M., & Dauenhauer, R. (1987). *Haa Shuká Our Ancestors*. University of Washington Press.
- Eggleston, K. (2017). *Online Tlingit verb dictionary: A database of over 1,100 conjugated Tlingit verbs*. Retrieved from <http://ankn.uaf.edu/~{}tlingitverbs/> (Unpublished online resource)
- Talmy, L. (1975). Semantics and syntax of motion. In J. P. Kimball (Ed.), *Syntax and semantics* (Vol. 4). Academic Press.

- Talmy, L. (2000). *Toward a cognitive semantics, volume 2: Typology and process in concept structuring*. The MIT Press. Retrieved from <https://doi.org/10.7551/mitpress/6848.001.0001>
doi: 10.7551/mitpress/6848.001.0001
- Twitchell, L. A. (2018). *Haa Dachxhánx'i Sáani Kagéiyi Yís: Haa Yoo Xh'atángi kei Naltseen, for our little grandchildren: Language revitalization among the Tlingit*. (Unpublished doctoral dissertation). University of Hawai'i at Hilo.